

THE VICE-CHANCELLOR'S ADDRESS

This is the One Hundred and Twenty-second (third) Congregation of the University of Hong Kong. No less than one hundred and twenty-two (three) times have the members of this University met together to welcome new additions to the roll of our graduates, who now number over twenty-two thousand. In the past twelve years, it has been my privilege to be present at many of these occasions; I calculate that I must have seen some fourteen-thousand young people receive their degrees. It is nonetheless with renewed pleasure and pride that I watch the pattern repeat itself here today, and I welcome you warmly, guests, friends of the University, and especially the parents and families of our new graduates, knowing that you will share these sentiments.

For you, the 781 (844) students who have received your degrees this morning (afternoon), I can only hope that you see in this ceremony the fitting culmination of your achievements. It is in recognition of your efforts that our splendour is on display, it is for you that we have left our normal daily pursuits and gathered together here, to offer our welcome into the ranks of graduates of the University of Hong Kong.

Our forms of ceremonial on these occasions have changed little since the University was established — and indeed are derived directly from a system much much older than the University itself. They might appear to have no relevance to the modern world, and indeed we could dispense with them overnight, without any effect on the quality of the degrees you have received today. But we cling to them because they represent the tradition which we have inherited, and of which you, today's graduates, are now an inseparable part.

But if our Congregation ceremonials hark back to earlier times, our thoughts on such a day will always turn to the future, with the graduates who are now on the threshold of a new and exciting life in the working world. More so than any generation of graduates, however, you must be considering what lies ahead, for it is a subject which is on everyone's mind. I want, for a moment then, to look forward, not to that date which you are perhaps already tired of hearing about, but beyond that, into the twenty-first century.

What is to be the role of our University in that coming world?

The basis of our answer is set out in the Joint Agreement, which states that the system of education in Hong Kong will remain unchanged for fifty years. I believe that our response to the challenge of the future should be to re-affirm our determination to uphold the goals set for us at the time of our founding in 1911, to maintain our devotion to the ideal of providing a first class education for all the young people entrusted to our care; but at the same time to show our willingness ever to adapt and respond to circumstances in order to meet our ideal.

This University is one of the oldest in the region. It was established, to quote from our original Ordinance, 'for the promotion of Learning, Arts, Science and Research', and that has been our aim ever since: not simply, I must emphasize, to produce graduates, but to *promote learning*. From time to time, universities like ours are accused of being 'ivory towers', devoted only to the pursuit of knowledge for its own sake. In my view this is not perhaps the sin it is sometimes thought to be, but this is neither the time nor place to pursue that argument, for I do not believe that this is something of which we can justly be accused. Conscious of our special position, for many decades, as the only University in Hong Kong, we have always sought to take our place in the community, deriving our inspiration from, and, I hope, bringing some benefit to the society of which we are a part. At the same time, the University has, I think, satisfactorily fulfilled its primary function of promoting learning in the last seventy years, and I have every expectation that it will continue to do so for the next seventy and beyond.

It is clear that the University will have a more vital function than ever in shaping our future during the years after 1997, and in the crucially important years which precede that date. Our needs as a community will be not so much for firmer government, which has been the tendency up to now, as for the strength that emerges naturally from the combined activities of our people. Here a university has an essential role to play, not only in providing the expertise to ensure productivity, but also in preserving the quality of independent thought in the minds of our young people, the leaders of tomorrow. In any society a university is an integrating force and this is brought about through the values and the standards instilled in its graduates. Hong Kong will need this quality of inner strength if it is to survive throughout the twenty-first century.

We are at the apex of an educational system the aim of which is to produce truly bilingual leaders. We have, over the years, given the community graduates who are competent in the Chinese and English languages as well as in their chosen skills and professions, and who are able to serve Hong Kong and to take their place in the council rooms and board rooms of the world, whether in London, New York or Beijing. Our graduates are used to handling two languages, they are at home in two cultures, with all the advantages this brings.

But will Hong Kong's need for such leaders continue? I do not see how it can be otherwise. If only in practical terms, the possibility of isolation is past. Modern means of travel and communication inevitably bring us all closer together, and China seems ready, indeed eager, now to become part of the international community of nations. For this it will require leaders who have not been educated in a parochial environment, who know something of the western world, and who, above all, can communicate. I do not doubt that the use of the Chinese language will increase in step with our closer connections with China. At the same time, I am also convinced that the demand for English will continue if Hong Kong is to maintain its international outlook and play its part in the development of China. Far from there being less need of the kind of leaders we have been producing, I believe that need will be greater, as will the role of those leaders in representing one-quarter of mankind.

The University needs two things in order to continue to produce these leaders. The first is independence, the vital element in any intellectual achievement. The freedom that we have always had, to select students, to appoint staff, to decide what to teach and how to teach it, is very precious to us. It is also essential for healthy community. We have trained your doctors and your dentists, your engineers, teachers and lawyers, and I do not for one moment decry these worthy professions. But a real univer-

sity also needs music, history and literature, science with no immediate practical application, social sciences and above all, the right to pursue any line of intellectual enquiry wherever it might lead. Each area of scholarship enriches the community; collectively they provide its strength. Without this freedom we will quickly wither into a mere 'degree factory'.

Secondly, we need the resources to carry out this task. University education of this quality is the most worthwhile investment any community can make, and one which should come high on its list of priorities regardless of other demands. Even short-term economies have an inevitable effect on some generations of students; with longer-term economies, the effects are even more far-reaching and serious. Cheap education is possible, but it will not produce the same sort of graduates as the young men and women here today, whose natural abilities have been brought to full flower only by the level of individual attention we are able to give them. It has been said many times that people are Hong Kong's greatest resource; only with the necessary investment of funds will that resource reach its full potential.

China has already made clear its view that not all its universities need be the same. I believe that over the fifty year period of the Agreement and well beyond, China will have a real need for a university such as ours, devoted to the promotion of learning and cultivation of leaders with bilingual ability and international outlook.

Mr. Chancellor, we are all aware that the success of the Joint Declaration and the future of Hong Kong will depend on the attitude of mind, on the sense of commitment, of our young people. I am sure that you will join with me in saying to the graduates of 1984, as to those who have gone before and who will come after: we place our trust in you. If the education which you have received is worthy of the name, and if the tradition of which you have become a part is a source of pride to you, cherish them! The future is in your hands.